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# Inclusive Entrepreneurship Policy in Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany, 2022

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**Sources:**
Governments of the Republic of Korea, Japan, the People's Republic of China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany, with the French Senate and National Assembly, the German Bundestag, INSEE, the U.S. Census Bureau and the public banks Bpifrance, the Japan Finance Corporation and KfW

*Summary:* This report reviews the inclusive entrepreneurship policy that the governments of Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany set out from January to December 2022 for women, young and older people, immigrants, persons with disabilities, the unemployed, rural people, minorities, veterans and the smallest self-employed, in six domains, and analyses it in its context, against theory and in practice. Law moved mostly for the smallest self-employed, finance relieved debt and widened guaranteed credit, and culture was addressed by weeks, contests and statistics. The best measures gave sole proprietors a protected estate and individual businesses equal treatment, widened credit through mission lenders and state credit programmes, and supported founders in deprived places; the worst left public markets without any measure for the groups. Instruments for women founders were mostly announced, persons with disabilities and older people were the least served, and implementation was reported as outputs.

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EEPR 2022

# Inclusive Entrepreneurship Policy in Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany, 2022

IFEED Institute for Entrepreneurial Ecosystem Development

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# Inclusive Entrepreneurship Policy in Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany, 2022

**Abstract**

This report reviews and analyses the inclusive entrepreneurship policy of the governments of the Republic of Korea, Japan, the People's Republic of China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany in their own plans, laws, budgets and announcements: the measures that supported, or withdrew support from, entrepreneurship by women, young and older people, immigrants, persons with disabilities, the unemployed, rural people, minorities, veterans and the smallest self-employed. The policies are reviewed in six domains — regulation and law, finance, culture, support, human capital and markets — and analysed in their context, against theories of problem representation, target populations, business failure, credit constraints and immigrant entrepreneurship, and in practice. Law moved mostly for the smallest self-employed: France gave sole proprietors a separate professional estate and opened the self-employed workers' allowance to owners of failed businesses, China's regulation on individual businesses took effect in November, and Korea passed accident insurance for labour providers from July 2023, while Japan's freelance law and Germany's social protection of the self-employed remained promises. Finance relieved debt and widened credit: Korea opened a fund to restructure the debts of the self-employed, China combined tax relief with guaranteed loans for key groups, and the United States widened mission lending and state credit programmes. The United Kingdom closed its allowance for claimants starting a business and reversed its own repeal of the off-payroll rules. Instruments for women founders, such as Germany's fund instrument and Japan's regional grant, were mostly announced or in draft, persons with disabilities and older people were the least served, routes for foreign founders widened mainly on paper, and implementation was reported as outputs rather than as who was reached. The period covered is January to December 2022.

**Keywords**

inclusive entrepreneurship, self-employment, sole proprietors, individual businesses, women entrepreneurs, immigrant founders, entrepreneurs with disabilities, debt relief, guaranteed loans, social insurance, procurement preferences

**JEL Classification**

L26, J16, J15, J68, H81, R58

Entrepreneurial Finance Research Division, Institute for Entrepreneurial Ecosystem Development (IFEED).

# 1 INTRODUCTION

**Key findings**

- Law moved mostly for the smallest self-employed. France gave sole proprietors a separate professional estate from mid-May and opened the self-employed workers' allowance to owners of businesses closed as not viable, China's regulation on individual businesses took effect on 1 November, and Korea passed accident insurance for labour providers from 1 July 2023; Japan's freelance law and Germany's social protection of the self-employed remained promises.
- Finance relieved debt and widened guaranteed credit. Korea's New Start Fund, with up to KRW 30 trillion of capacity, opened on 4 October, China combined tax relief with guaranteed loans for key groups, and the United States widened mission lending and approved more than USD 2.25 billion of state credit plans by 19 August.
- Women were counted more than they were reached. They were a record 24.5 % of the founders financed by Japan's public lender, 19 % of start-up founders in Germany and 41 % of creators of sole proprietorships in France, while Germany's fund instrument for women, Japan's regional grant and Korea's larger fund allocation for women's firms were announced or in draft.
- Support was also withdrawn. The United Kingdom closed the New Enterprise Allowance in January, announced a five-year freeze of the profits threshold for the self-employed and reversed its announced repeal of the off-payroll rules; Germany's restart aid ran only to June.
- Routes for foreign founders widened mainly on paper. Japan eased premises rules for foreign founders in special zones and the United Kingdom eased settlement on the Innovator route, but Japan's private-body visa route and Korea's easier visa renewal were plans.
- Persons with disabilities and older people were the least served. Japan offered disabled founders a welfare loan and general support, the British measures for people over 50 prepared them for employment only, and falling founding by older people in Germany met no measure.
- Implementation was reported as outputs: survival from one surveyed cohort in France, purchase ratios but not purchases in Korea, and no take-up of guaranteed loans in China.

Inclusive entrepreneurship policy covers the measures that support, or withdraw support from, entrepreneurship and self-employment by people who are under-represented or disadvantaged in it. Problem definitions, it has been argued, carry assumptions about causes and responsibility (Rochefort & Cobb, 1993), the representation of a problem implies what is left unsaid (Bacchi, 2009), and policies construct their target groups as deserving or undeserving (Schneider & Ingram, 1993). This report applies these ideas, and evidence on the barriers groups face, to Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany in 2022. It asks three questions:

1. What policies did each country set out for under-represented and disadvantaged entrepreneurs in each domain of the entrepreneurial ecosystem in 2022?

2. How did the policies arise and how were they justified, how far were they valid in theory, and what had they achieved in practice by the end of the year?
3. What were their limitations, and what follows for policy?

The report draws on the literature on women in entrepreneurship policy (Ahl & Nelson, 2015), credit constraints and discrimination (Blanchflower, Levine, & Zimmerman, 2003; Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998), loan guarantees (Riding, Madill, & Haines, 2007), start-up subsidies (Caliendo & Künn, 2011), business failure (Armour & Cumming, 2008; Lee, Peng, & Barney, 2007), entry regulation (Klapper, Laeven, & Rajan, 2006), immigrant (Hunt, 2011; Kerr & Kerr, 2020), disabled (Renko, Parker Harris, & Caldwell, 2016) and older entrepreneurs (Kautonen, Down, & Minniti, 2014), procurement preferences (Marion, 2009), regional differences (Fritsch & Storey, 2014) and the evaluation of entrepreneurship policy (Acs, Åstebro, Audretsch, & Robinson, 2016).

Section 2 reviews and assesses the key policies of 2022 in six domains; Section 3 analyses them in their context, against theory and in practice; Section 4 sets out their contested points and theoretical limitations, and Section 5 their implications.

The report rests on the plans, laws, budgets, reports and announcements in which Korea, Japan, China, the United Kingdom, the United States, France and Germany set out their inclusive entrepreneurship policy in 2022: cabinet plans, acts, bills, decrees and regulations, budgets and budget reports of parliaments, written parliamentary answers, official statistics, and the releases of ministries, agencies and the public banks — Bpifrance, the Japan Finance Corporation and KfW — acting for the state. Table 1 lists the sources by country; quotations from sources not in English are IFEED's translations.

***Table 1: Government plans, laws, reports and announcements reviewed***

| Subject | Issuing bodies | Date and type | Period covered | Description |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Korea | | | | |
| Youth Start-up Academy pilot | MSS | 10 February 2022 Press release | February 2022 | Private-led academy for founders under 40. |
| Foreign founders | MOJ | 4 April 2022 Press release | 2015–2022 | Start-up visa; immigration centre. |
| Accident insurance act | MOEL | 29 May 2022 Press release | May 2022 | Cover for labour providers from 2023. |
| Centres for middle-aged founders | MSS | 7 June 2022 Press release | June 2022 | Centres; boot camp; barriers. |
| Re-challenge grant | MSS | 13 July 2022 Press release | July–August 2022 | Grants for closed shops. |
| Policy for small business owners | MSS | 25 August 2022 Press release | August 2022 | Policy direction of the new government. |
| New Start Fund design | FSC | 29 August 2022 Press release | August 2022 | Debt adjustment for the self-employed. |
| K-Startup global strategy | MSS | 8 September 2022 Strategy | September 2022 | Start-up visa renewal planned. |

| Subject | Issuing bodies | Date and type | Period covered | Description |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Decree on disabled-owned firms | MSS | 13 September 2022 Press release | September 2022 | Social cooperatives included. |
| New Start Fund launch | FSC | 23 September 2022 Press release | October 2022 | Fund opened on 4 October. |
| Women Venture Week | MSS | 9 November 2022 Press release | 2018–2022 | Funds, guarantee, women's programme. |
| Public purchase convention | MSS | 24 November 2022 Press release | November 2022 | Statutory purchase ratios. |
| Entrepreneurship survey | MSS | 19 December 2022 Statistics | 2019–2022 | Scores by sex and age. |
| MSS budget for 2023 | MSS | 26 December 2022 Press release | December 2022 | Budget as passed. |
| Small business notice 2023 | MSS | 28 December 2022 Press release | December 2022 | Premium support; fast track. |
| Policy funds; start-up notice | MSS | 29 December 2022 Press releases | December 2022 | Youth fund; youth programmes. |
| Japan | | | | |
| Regional vitalisation | Internal affairs ministry | January 2022 Briefing | 2020–2022 | Community cooperators. |
| Priority policy for women | Cabinet headquarters | 3 June 2022 Priority policy | 2022 | Bonus points in procurement. |
| Action plan; basic policy | Cabinet | 7 June 2022 Cabinet decisions | 2022 | Freelancers; guarantees. |
| White papers | Cabinet Office | June 2022 White papers | 2021–2022 | Disabled and older founders. |
| JFC loans, first half | JFC | 15 November 2022 News release | April–September 2022 | Loans to women before founding. |
| Start-up five-year plan | New capitalism council | 28 November 2022 Plan | November 2022 | Visa; guarantees; Dejima. |
| Survey of new businesses | JFC Research Institute | 30 November 2022 News release | 2022 | Women's share of founders. |
| Supplementary budget (draft) | Cabinet Office | November 2022 Budget outline | November 2022 | Regional grant for women. |
| Social security council | Cabinet council | 16 December 2022 Report | December 2022 | Freelancers' insurance. |
| Guarantee reform programme | Economy ministry et al. | 23 December 2022 Programme | December 2022 | Loans without guarantees. |
| Special-zone founder guideline | Immigration agency | December 2022 Guidelines | December 2022 | Co-working premises. |
| China | | | | |
| Veterans in private firms | Veterans ministry et al. | 6 January 2022 Joint opinions | 2022 | Loans; supplier priority. |
| Demonstration bases | NDRC et al. | 8 February 2022 Joint notice | 2022 | Graduates' entrepreneurship. |

| Subject | Issuing bodies | Date and type | Period covered | Description |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Six taxes and two fees | Ministry of Finance; STA | 1 March 2022 Announcement | 2022 | Local tax halving. |
| Government work report | State Council | 5 March 2022 Report | 2021–2022 | Targets and relief for 2022. |
| Income tax relief | Ministry of Finance; STA | 14 March 2022 Announcement | 2022 | Small low-profit firms. |
| People lifted out of poverty | MOHRSS et al. | 15 March 2022 Joint notice | 2022 | Employment; start-up loans. |
| Taiwan residents | Taiwan office et al. | 16 March 2022 Joint notice | March 2022 | Individual business registration. |
| Disabled people's employment | State Council office | 25 March 2022 Action plan | 2022 | Platforms; training. |
| Graduates and young people | State Council office | 5 May 2022 Notice | 2022 | Start-up support; anti-discrimination. |
| Stabilising the economy | State Council | 24 May 2022 Notice | 2022 | Deferral; new urban residents. |
| Regulation on individual businesses | State Council | 1 October 2022 Regulation | November 2022 | Order No. 755. |
| Migrant workers | MOHRSS et al. | 9 November 2022 Joint opinions | 2022 | Return-home start-ups. |
| Procurement from poor areas | Finance ministry office et al. | 17 November 2022 Joint notice | 2022 | The 832 Platform. |
| United Kingdom | | | | |
| Levelling up | DLUHC | 2 February 2022 White paper | 2022 | In-work progression. |
| Immigration rules | Home Office | 15 March 2022 Memorandum | March–April 2022 | Innovator route. |
| Inclusive Britain | Race Disparity Unit; DLUHC | 17 March 2022 Action plan | 2012–2022 | Ethnic minority entrepreneurs. |
| Spring Statement | HM Treasury | 23 March 2022 Fiscal statement | March 2022 | Class 2 relief; thresholds. |
| Procurement Bill | Cabinet Office | 12 May 2022 News story | May 2022 | Duties towards SMEs. |
| Access to Work | DWP | 24 May 2022 Written answer | May 2022 | Disabled freelancers. |
| Taskforce for women | Equalities Office | 26 May 2022 News story | May 2022 | Target for women founders. |
| New Enterprise Allowance | DWP | 15 June 2022 Statistics | 2011–2021 | Closure; participants. |
| Minimum Income Floor | DWP | 27 June 2022 Written answer | June 2022 | Cost-of-living payment. |
| Investing in Women Code | BEIS | 28 June 2022 Press release | 2021–2022 | Deals with women founders. |
| Small business survey | BEIS | 31 August 2022 Statistics | 2021 | Women- and minority-led firms. |

| Subject | Issuing bodies | Date and type | Period covered | Description |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Rural prosperity fund | Rural affairs; DLUHC | 3 September 2022 News story | September 2022 | Rural top-up. |
| Growth Plan | HM Treasury | 23 September 2022 Fiscal statement | September 2022 | Contributions; off-payroll repeal. |
| Start Up Loans | BEIS | 25 September 2022 Press release | 2012–2022 | Eligibility widened. |
| Change of Prime Minister | Prime Minister's Office | 25 October 2022 Speech; news story | October 2022 | Outgoing and new Prime Minister. |
| Autumn Statement | HM Treasury | 17 November 2022 Fiscal statement | November 2022 | Reversals; threshold freeze. |
| United States | | | | |
| Equitable recovery | SBA | 21 January 2022 Press release | 2021–2022 | Centres; navigators. |
| Indian business incubators | Interior | 23 March 2022 Notice | March–May 2022 | Grants for incubators. |
| SBA budget request | SBA | 28 March 2022 Budget request | 2020–2022 | Requests; results for 2020–2021. |
| Community Advantage notice | SBA | 29 April 2022 Notice | May 2022 | Changes from 31 May. |
| Small Business Week | President | 29 April 2022 Proclamation | May 2022 | Applications; contracting pledge. |
| State credit initiative | Treasury | 19 May 2022 Press release | May 2022 | First state plans. |
| Disadvantaged enterprises | Transportation | 21 July 2022 Proposed rule | July–October 2022 | Net worth cap. |
| State credit initiative | Treasury | 19 August 2022 Press release | May–August 2022 | Approvals by August. |
| Rural microenterprise | Agriculture | 31 August 2022 Notice | September–December 2022 | Loans and grants. |
| 8(a) ownership proposal | SBA | 9 September 2022 Proposed rule | September–November 2022 | Ownership; competitions. |
| PRIME grants | SBA | 22 September 2022 Press release | 2021–2022 | Grants to micro-lenders. |
| Independent contractors | Labor | 13 October 2022 Proposed rule | October–November 2022 | Classification test. |
| Mission lending companies | SBA | 7 November 2022 Proposed rule | November–December 2022 | Moratorium to end. |
| Business ownership data | Census Bureau | 10 November 2022 Press release | 2020 | Owners by group. |
| Disadvantage thresholds | SBA | 17 November 2022 Interim final rule | December 2022 | Thresholds for inflation. |

| Subject | Issuing bodies | Date and type | Period covered | Description |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Veteran certification | SBA | 29 November 2022 Final rule | November–December 2022 | Certification from 2023. |
| France | | | | |
| Micro-entrepreneurs | MEFR | 28 January 2022 Press release | December 2021–January 2022 | Contribution exemptions. |
| Business creations 2021 | INSEE | 2 February 2022 Statistics | 2015–2021 | Creators by sex and age. |
| Bpifrance in 2021 | Bpifrance | 3 February 2022 Press release | 2021 | Honour loans; micro-credit. |
| Independent-worker act | Parliament | 14 February 2022 Act | February–September 2022 | Act No. 2022-172. |
| Rebound conference | MEFR | 16 February 2022 Press release | February 2022 | Failure; rebound portal. |
| French Tech Springboard | MEFR | 21 February 2022 Press release | 2021–2022 | Budget; second edition. |
| Self-employed allowance | Prime Minister | 30 March 2022 Decrees | April 2022 | Allowance amount. |
| Professional estate | Prime Minister | 28 April 2022 Decree | April–May 2022 | Estate defined. |
| Sole proprietors in difficulty | Prime Minister | 14 June 2022 Decree | June 2022 | Insolvency adapted. |
| Training of the self-employed | Prime Minister | 29 June 2022 Decree | September 2022 | Training claims. |
| Entrepreneurship in towns | Bpifrance | 8 September 2022 Press release | September 2022 | Winners of the call. |
| French Tech Springboard | MEFIDS | 15 September 2022 Press release | 2020–2022 | Third edition; survey. |
| Women's rights delegation | National Assembly | 27 October 2022 Report | October 2022 | Women's entrepreneurship line. |
| Student entrepreneurs | MESR | October 2022 Press kit | 2019–2022 | Status holders by sex. |
| Senate budget reports | Senate | 17 November 2022 Budget reports | 2022 | Zones; employment measures. |
| City Talents contest | Bpifrance | 25 November 2022 Press release | 2022 | Applicants and winners. |
| Hiring aid decree | Prime Minister | 28 December 2022 Decree | December 2022 | Date moved to end-2023. |
| Finance act for 2023 | Parliament | 30 December 2022 Act | December 2022 | City policy credits. |
| Germany | | | | |
| Covid aid overview | Federal Government | 4 January 2022 Overview | 2021–2022 | Restart aid; basic income. |

| Subject | Issuing bodies | Date and type | Period covered | Description |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Bridging aid IV | Federal Government | 7 January 2022 News article | January–March 2022 | Restart aid 2022. |
| Annual economic report | Federal Government | 26 January 2022 Report | 2022 | Social protection plans. |
| Bridging aid extended | Federal Government | 1 April 2022 News article | April–June 2022 | Aid to end-June. |
| This is EXIST 2021 | BMWK | April 2022 Programme report | 2018–2021 | Women in EXIST. |
| KfW start-up monitor | KfW Research | 30 May 2022 Report | 2020–2021 | Founders by sex and age. |
| Start-up Strategy | Federal Government | 28 July 2022 Strategy | July 2022 | Women; migrants; regions. |
| Maternity protection | Bundestag | 26 September 2022 Parliamentary news | September 2022 | Working group. |
| Citizen's income bill | Federal Government | 10 October 2022 Bill | October 2022 | Savings of the self-employed. |
| Female entrepreneurship | KfW Research | 14 November 2022 Study and release | 2017–2021 | Stereotypes; venture deals. |
| Citizen's income decision | Bundestag | 25 November 2022 Decision | November 2022 | Conciliation result adopted. |

Source: The plans, laws, reports and announcements listed. Periods covered and descriptions: IFEED.

Note: Where a source has several parts, citations name the part (for example, plan or press release) before the page. Abbreviations: BEIS, Department for Business, Energy and Industrial Strategy; BMWK, Federal Ministry for Economic Affairs and Climate Action; COVID-19, coronavirus disease 2019; DLUHC, Department for Levelling Up, Housing and Communities; DWP, Department for Work and Pensions; EXIST, Business Start-ups from Science (federal programme); FSC, Financial Services Commission; HC, House of Commons paper; HM, Her or His Majesty's; INSEE, National Institute of Statistics and Economic Studies; IPO, initial public offering; JFC, Japan Finance Corporation; KfW, Germany's federal promotional bank; MEFIDS, Ministry of the Economy, Finance and Industrial and Digital Sovereignty; MEFR, Ministry of the Economy, Finance and Recovery; MESR, Ministry of Higher Education and Research; MOEL, Ministry of Employment and Labor; MOHRSS, Ministry of Human Resources and Social Security; MOJ, Ministry of Justice of Korea; MSS, Ministry of SMEs and Startups; NDRC, National Development and Reform Commission; PRIME, Program for Investment in Micro-Entrepreneurs; SBA, U.S. Small Business Administration; SME, small and medium-sized enterprise; STA, State Taxation Administration; UK, United Kingdom; US, United States; VAT, value added tax.

# 2 REVIEW OF INCLUSIVE ENTREPRENEURSHIP POLICIES

This section reviews the key policies of 2022 in six domains, adapted from Isenberg's domains of the entrepreneurial ecosystem (Isenberg, 2011): regulation and law; finance, in grants, funding and financial infrastructure; culture; institutional support; human capital, in education and training and in labour; and markets, in market and industry support, initial public offerings (IPO) and exit. The groups covered are women, young and older people, immigrants and foreign founders, persons with disabilities, the unemployed and people on low incomes, people in rural and lagging regions, ethnic minorities and veterans, and the smallest self-employed.

## 2.1 REGULATION AND LAW

Law moved mostly for the smallest self-employed, through insurance, insolvency and the status of individual businesses, while laws for freelancers and social protection of the self-employed remained promises.

### 2.1.1 KOREA: THE ACCIDENT INSURANCE AMENDMENT AND THE DISABILITY DECREE

On 29 May the National Assembly passed an amendment of the Industrial Accident Compensation Insurance Act that abolishes the requirement that special-type workers work mainly for one business and covers them and platform workers as labour providers from 1 July 2023; the MOEL expected about 630,000 more people to be covered in the short term (MOEL, 29 May 2022, p. 2). On 13 September the Cabinet approved a decree that brings social cooperatives run by disabled people within the definition of disabled-owned enterprises, opening priority purchasing and support to them, due to take effect on publication from 20 September (MSS, 13 September 2022, pp. 1–2). Under a decree of August, support for the employment insurance premiums of the self-employed will extend from one-person owners to all small business owners in 2023, rising from KRW 3.6 billion to KRW 5 billion (MSS, 26 December 2022, p. 4; MSS, 28 December 2022, release). The new government announced that small business owners would be defined by turnover alone, so that owners who hire staff keep their support (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 3).

This was a mixed policy. The accident insurance amendment, passed although it takes effect in mid-2023, will protect labour providers who serve several clients, the decree opens public purchasing to cooperatives run by disabled people, and premium support will reach every small business owner from 2023. But the new definition of a small business owner, which decides who qualifies for support, was a plan.

### 2.1.2 JAPAN: THE PLANNED FREELANCE LAW AND THE RE-CHALLENGE RULE

The Cabinet's action plan of 7 June counted 4.62 million freelancers, most of them outside the Subcontract Act, and promised to submit a law on fair transactions with them to the Diet early (Cabinet of Japan, 7 June 2022, action plan, p. 17), but no bill was submitted in 2022. The Start-up Development Five-year Plan of 28 November reported that a 2022 amendment of the Employment Insurance Act had created a rule leaving up to three years spent running a new business out of the period, normally one year after leaving a job, in which unemployment benefit can be claimed,

without stating when it applies (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022, p. 9). On 23 December the Financial Services Agency amended its guidelines so that from April 2023 lenders must explain why they need a personal guarantee (Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry, Financial Services Agency, & Ministry of Finance of Japan, 23 December 2022, p. 2 and release). A Cabinet council recommended employee insurance for freelancers who are workers and a study of a benefit for self-employed parents (Council for Building a Social Security System for All Generations, 16 December 2022, pp. 11, 14).

This was a mixed policy. The amended guidelines, adopted for April 2023, and the re-challenge rule, once applied, lower the personal cost of trying a business, a cost that, it has been argued, deters entry (Lee et al., 2007). But the rule's start was not stated, the freelance law, the main protection planned for the smallest self-employed, was still a promise, and their social insurance was a recommendation.

### 2.1.3 CHINA: THE REGULATION ON INDIVIDUAL BUSINESSES (ORDER NO. 755)

The State Council's Regulation on promoting the development of individual businesses (Order No. 755), adopted on 26 September, took effect on 1 November (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 1 October 2022, order and Art. 39). It bars discrimination against individual businesses in licensing, procurement and bidding, simplifies annual reports and conversion into enterprises, asks local governments to help them by type and in joining social insurance, and forbids forcing workers to register as individual businesses or judging local governments by growth in their number (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 1 October 2022, Arts. 5, 12, 13, 16, 17, 22, 30, 32). Residents of Taiwan may register (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 1 October 2022, Art. 37), and from 16 March those in pilot areas for trade in services could register directly in 122 lines of business (Taiwan Affairs Office of the State Council, Ministry of Commerce, & State Administration for Market Regulation, 16 March 2022, items 1–3).

This was a good policy. The Regulation is in force and lowers the administrative cost of running, changing and converting the smallest firms, a cost of the kind found to deter entry (Klapper et al., 2006), and its ban on forced registration protects people pushed into self-employment. Its limits are that it names no group of founders and that no measure for women, minority, older or foreign founders appears in the State Council policy library for 2022.

### 2.1.4 UNITED KINGDOM: CLASS 2 CONTRIBUTIONS AND THE OFF-PAYROLL RULES

The Spring Statement of 23 March announced that from April self-employed people with profits between the Small Profits Threshold and the Lower Profits Limit would pay no Class 2 contributions, a cut for about 500,000 people of up to GBP 165 a year, and that from July the Lower Profits Limit would rise to GBP 12,570 (HM Treasury, 23 March 2022, paras. 2.11, 3.7), as it did (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, para. 5.17). On 23 September the Growth Plan of Liz Truss's government announced lower contribution rates from November and the repeal of the off-payroll working reforms from April 2023 (HM Treasury, 23 September 2022, paras. 3.20, 3.44); on 17 November the Autumn Statement of Rishi Sunak's government reversed the repeal (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, table 5.2) and announced that the Lower Profits Limit would stay at GBP 12,570

for five years from April 2023 (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, para. 5.17). Self-employed claimants whose Universal Credit the Minimum Income Floor had reduced to zero were not eligible for the cost-of-living payment (DWP, 27 June 2022, answer).

This was a mixed policy. The higher Lower Profits Limit, in place from July, and the Class 2 relief lower the costs of low-earning self-employed people while keeping their credits. But the threshold that relieves them is to be frozen for five years as prices rise, the off-payroll repeal was announced and withdrawn within two months, and the Minimum Income Floor excluded claimants without an award from cost-of-living support.

### 2.1.5 UNITED STATES: VETERAN CERTIFICATION AND DISADVANTAGE THRESHOLDS

Under a final rule of 29 November the SBA will take over the certification of veteran-owned and service-disabled veteran-owned small businesses on 1 January 2023, for three years at a time (SBA, 29 November 2022, pp. 73400, 73405). From 19 December it raised the net worth ceiling for economic disadvantage in its 8(a) and women-owned programmes from USD 750,000 to USD 850,000 and the income test from USD 350,000 to USD 400,000 (SBA, 17 November 2022, p. 69129). Other rules were only proposed: changes to 8(a) ownership (SBA, 9 September 2022, p. 55642), nonprofit mission-based lending companies after a moratorium in place since 1982 (SBA, 7 November 2022, pp. 66963–66964), a higher net worth cap for the Department of Transportation's disadvantaged business enterprises (U.S. Department of Transportation, 21 July 2022, p. 43636) and a broader test of whether a worker is an independent contractor (U.S. Department of Labor, 13 October 2022, p. 62219).

This was a mixed policy. The higher thresholds keep owners eligible as their firms grow with inflation, and SBA certification will give veterans one government-wide status. But the rules that would widen mission lending and raise the transport cap were proposals, as was the test that decides whether freelancers are in business for themselves.

### 2.1.6 FRANCE: ACT NO. 2022-172 ON INDEPENDENT PROFESSIONAL ACTIVITY

Act No. 2022-172 of 14 February creates a single statute for the sole proprietor, whose professional estate is separate from the personal one, so that business creditors can in general claim only on the professional estate; it applied from mid-May, and where the estates were kept apart personal debts go to over-indebtedness proceedings (Parliament of France, 14 February 2022, Arts. 1, 5, 19). Decrees defined the professional estate on 28 April and on 14 June adapted insolvency rules and closed the limited-liability sole-proprietor status to new entrepreneurs (Prime Minister of France, 28 April 2022, Art. 2; Prime Minister of France, 14 June 2022, Art. 1). From 1 March the act opens the self-employed workers' allowance to people whose business closed as not viable, with a five-year bar on a new claim (Parliament of France, 14 February 2022, Arts. 11, 19), and a decree set it at EUR 26.30 a day from 1 April (Prime Minister of France, 30 March 2022, Decree No. 2022-451, Art. 1).

This was a good policy. Separate estates and over-indebtedness relief lower the personal cost of failure for the smallest self-employed, a cost whose reduction through more forgiving bankruptcy law has been found to go with higher self-employment (Armour & Cumming, 2008), and the

allowance gives owners of failed businesses an income, with its decrees in force within weeks. Its limit is that it names no group among the self-employed.

#### 2.1.7 GERMANY: SELF-EMPLOYED PROTECTION AND THE CITIZEN'S INCOME BILL

The Annual Economic Report of 26 January announced easier voluntary unemployment insurance for the self-employed, a duty for new self-employed people without cover to provide for old age, and income-related health contributions (Federal Government of Germany, 26 January 2022, p. 78); no bill followed in 2022. On 26 September the Government told the Petitions Committee that it was working on maternity protection for the self-employed (German Bundestag, 26 September 2022, report), and the Start-up Strategy named a modernisation of their parental allowance without a bill (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 10). Simplified access to basic income support for them was extended to 31 March (Federal Government of Germany, 4 January 2022, p. 2). The Citizen's Income bill, whose conciliation form the Bundestag adopted on 25 November (German Bundestag, 25 November 2022, decision), would leave their old-age savings out of the asset test (Federal Government of Germany, 10 October 2022, p. 16).

This was a mixed policy. Simplified basic income support kept a safety net for the self-employed in the first quarter, and the bill adopted by the Bundestag would protect their old-age savings. But their insurance against unemployment, old age and maternity remained an announcement, a working group and a statement of intent.

### 2.2 FINANCE: GRANTS, FUNDING AND FINANCIAL INFRASTRUCTURE

Finance was the main instrument, through debt relief, public lenders, tax relief and guaranteed loans, but the instruments for women founders were mostly announced.

#### 2.2.1 KOREA: THE NEW START FUND AND THE RE-CHALLENGE GRANT

The FSC's New Start Fund, with up to KRW 30 trillion of capacity, restructures the loans of sole proprietors and small firms hit by COVID-19 that are in or near default, writing off 60 % to 80 % of the debt above the value of their assets for those 90 days or more in default, and up to 90 % for recipients of livelihood support, severely disabled people and low-income people aged 70 or over (FSC, 29 August 2022, release, p. 1, and annex, pp. 5, 11); it opened on 4 October (FSC, 23 September 2022, p. 1). Owners who had closed between December 2021 and May 2022 could apply for a re-challenge grant of KRW 1 million, KRW 50 billion for about 50,000 owners (MSS, 13 July 2022, p. 1). The policy funds for 2023 raise the fund for founders aged 39 or under from KRW 210 billion to KRW 250 billion (MSS, 29 December 2022, policy funds, p. 2). The guarantee for women-owned firms, with a lower fee, had guaranteed KRW 2.7659 trillion in 2018 to 2022, and the MSS planned to raise the fund-of-funds allocation for women's firms from KRW 12 billion to KRW 13 billion, pending the budget (MSS, 9 November 2022, pp. 1–2).

This was a mixed policy. The New Start Fund and the re-challenge grant lower the cost of failure for owners who closed or fell into debt, with deeper relief for disabled and older borrowers, and the youth fund and women's guarantee relax the credit constraint that deters founders without wealth

(Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998). But the larger allocation for women's firms was a plan, and most of the money relieved debt and closure rather than financed founding.

### 2.2.2 JAPAN: JFC START-UP LOANS AND THE GUARANTEE REFORM PROGRAMME

From April to September 2022 the Japan Finance Corporation (JFC) lent before founding to 7,970 borrowers, and its loans to 2,219 women stood at 108.1 % of the same period of fiscal year 2019, against 90.8 % for men (JFC, 15 November 2022, table 2); it also lent to older founders at preferential rates (Cabinet Office of Japan, June 2022, ageing white paper, section 2). The Management Guarantee Reform Programme of 23 December set out a 100 % credit guarantee of up to JPY 35 million without a personal guarantee for firms within five years of founding from March 2023 and relaxed JFC terms for such loans from February 2023, and reported that the Shoko Chukin Bank had in principle dropped personal guarantees for start-up loans from October 2022 (Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry et al., 23 December 2022, p. 1). The draft supplementary budget added JPY 675 million to the regional grant for women's empowerment, which funds local training of women entrepreneurs among other uses (Cabinet Office of Japan, November 2022, p. 3).

This was a mixed policy. The JFC's loans reach women, young and older founders in thousands, and loans without personal guarantees lower the personal cost of failure. But the new guarantee and the relaxed JFC terms were announced plans for 2023, and the grant for women was in a draft budget.

### 2.2.3 CHINA: ANNOUNCEMENTS NO. 10 AND 13 AND GUARANTEED START-UP LOANS

Announcement No. 13 of the Ministry of Finance and the STA taxes small low-profit firms' annual taxable income between CNY 1 million and 3 million at an effective 5 %, and under Announcement No. 10 provinces may halve six local taxes and two surcharges for small-scale VAT payers, small low-profit firms and individual businesses, both for three years from 1 January 2022 (Ministry of Finance of the People's Republic of China & STA, 1 March 2022, item 1; Ministry of Finance of the People's Republic of China & STA, 14 March 2022, items 1, 3). The State Council encouraged banks to defer loans to small firms and individual businesses and announced that new urban residents from the countryside would be brought within guaranteed start-up loans (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 24 May 2022, measures 8, 32). Guaranteed loans with interest subsidies were offered to graduates, with a start-up subsidy and about 30 % of government-built start-up space free (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 May 2022, item 3), to people lifted out of poverty (MOHRSS, NDRC, Ministry of Finance, Ministry of Agriculture and Rural Affairs, & National Rural Revitalisation Administration, 15 March 2022, item 7), to veterans (Ministry of Veterans Affairs et al., 6 January 2022, Part II, item 5) and to returning migrant workers (MOHRSS, NDRC, Ministry of Finance, Ministry of Agriculture and Rural Affairs, & National Rural Revitalisation Administration, 9 November 2022, item 8).

This was a mixed policy. The tax relief is in force, and subsidised guaranteed loans for graduates, poor households, veterans and migrant workers lower both the cost of starting and the credit constraint for people without wealth (Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998). But the loan deferral was a

request to banks, the loans for new urban residents were announced, and neither take-up nor whether the credit was incremental, the test applied to such guarantees (Riding et al., 2007), was reported; women were not named.

### 2.2.4 UNITED KINGDOM: START UP LOANS AND THE INVESTING IN WOMEN CODE

On 25 September the BEIS widened the government-backed Start Up Loans, of up to GBP 25,000 at 6 % with mentoring, to firms trading for up to three years, added second loans for firms up to five years old and made 33,000 new loans available; more than 95,000 loans had been made since 2012 (BEIS, 25 September 2022, release), 21 % to people from an ethnic minority background (Race Disparity Unit & DLUHC, 17 March 2022, pp. 79–80). Under the voluntary Investing in Women Code, 34 % of the signatories' venture capital deals in 2021 were in companies with at least one female founder, against 24 % across the industry (BEIS, 28 June 2022, release), and Inclusive Britain promised a pilot of data on the ethnicity of entrepreneurs seeking finance (Race Disparity Unit & DLUHC, 17 March 2022, p. 80). A rural fund of up to GBP 110 million was announced in September (Department for Environment, Food and Rural Affairs & DLUHC, 3 September 2022, release).

This was a mixed policy. Wider Start Up Loans reach founders whom traditional lenders turn away, and the Code asks investors, not women, to change, which the evidence on investor bias supports (Ewens & Townsend, 2020). But the Code is voluntary, the ethnicity pilot and the rural fund were announcements, and no finance was aimed at disabled, older or immigrant founders.

### 2.2.5 UNITED STATES: COMMUNITY ADVANTAGE AND THE STATE CREDIT INITIATIVE

From 31 May the SBA's Community Advantage pilot of mission-based lenders, extended by two years and reopened to new lenders, could lend up to USD 350,000 instead of USD 250,000, and no longer excluded businesses with an associate who is incarcerated, on probation or parole or indicted (SBA, 29 April 2022, pp. 25398, 25400). On 19 May the Treasury approved the first state plans under the State Small Business Credit Initiative of nearly USD 10 billion, which reserves USD 1 billion of incentives for reaching underserved entrepreneurs, when Maryland expected 70 % of its new loans to go to minority-owned and 40 % to women-owned businesses (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 19 May 2022, release); more than USD 2.25 billion had been approved by 19 August (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 19 August 2022, release). On 22 September the SBA awarded USD 7.2 million of PRIME grants to 38 organisations that finance and train low-income micro-entrepreneurs, 30 % more than a year earlier (SBA, 22 September 2022, release).

This was a good policy. Mission lenders, state credit programmes with incentives to reach underserved owners and grants to micro-lenders address the credit constraints and discrimination that the evidence finds for founders without wealth and for black-owned firms (Blanchflower et al., 2003; Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998), and all were in force, approved or awarded. Its limit is that whom the loans reached, and whether the guaranteed credit was incremental (Riding et al., 2007), was not reported.

### 2.2.6 FRANCE: EXEMPTIONS FOR MICRO-ENTREPRENEURS AND HONOUR LOANS

In January the ministry announced that micro-entrepreneurs in the hardest-hit sectors would be exempted from all contributions for December or January if their activity fell by at least 65 %, and from half if it fell by 30 % to 65 % (MEFR, 28 January 2022, release). Bpifrance reported that in 2021 it had granted more than 8,000 honour loans to creators and that the Social Cohesion Fund it manages for the State had guaranteed more than 36,000 professional micro-credits (Bpifrance, 3 February 2022, release). The State announced a significant increase in its support for the Entrepreneurs' Rebound Portal in 2022, without an amount (MEFR, 16 February 2022, release), and the 2023 finance bill held the line for women's entrepreneurship and diversity of trades at EUR 3.9 million (Delegation for Women's Rights of the National Assembly, 27 October 2022, pp. 11, 13).

This was a mixed policy. The exemptions were to relieve micro-entrepreneurs in the hardest-hit sectors, and honour loans and guaranteed micro-credit had reached creators in 2021. But support for owners who fail was promised without a sum, and the line for women's entrepreneurship and diversity of trades was held flat at bill stage.

### 2.2.7 GERMANY: THE RESTART AID AND THE FUTURE FUND INSTRUMENT FOR WOMEN

The restart aid of 2022 paid solo self-employed people with losses from the pandemic up to EUR 1,500 a month for January to March (Federal Government of Germany, 7 January 2022, article) and was extended unchanged to the end of June (Federal Government of Germany, 1 April 2022, article); its first round had paid EUR 1.591 billion on 254,936 approved applications (Federal Government of Germany, 4 January 2022, p. 1). The Start-up Strategy adopted on 27 July announced an instrument in the Future Fund for women founders and diverse venture capital teams, and an EXIST Women funding line with longer funding when a team member has a child (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 10), without amounts or dates; in November KfW described the instrument as initiated (KfW Research, 14 November 2022, press release).

This was a mixed policy. The restart aid reached solo self-employed people whom the bridging aid served poorly. But it ran only to the end of June, and the fund instrument, which addresses the evidence that investors favour male founders (Ewens & Townsend, 2020; Kanze, Huang, Conley, & Higgins, 2018), and the funding line for women were announcements without money.

## 2.3 CULTURE

Culture was addressed by weeks, contests, statements and statistics, and the statistics showed women well below half of founders wherever they were counted.

### 2.3.1 KOREA: THE ENTREPRENEURSHIP SURVEY AND WOMEN VENTURE WEEK

The new government said that small business owners had been seen as subsistence-type and set out to make them innovative entrepreneurs (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 4). The MSS's entrepreneurship survey of 19 December scored men at 58.2 and women at 54.6, people in their 20s highest at 59.8 and those in their 60s lowest at 52.5 (MSS, 19 December 2022, p. 3). The third Women Venture Week, on 9 November, honoured women-led ventures, whose technology start-

ups had risen by 6.8 % in the year before against 3.1 % for men (MSS, 9 November 2022, p. 1), and the MSS cited a survey in which middle-aged founders named raising funds (71.7 %) and fear of failure (41 %) as barriers (MSS, 7 June 2022, p. 1).

This was a mixed policy. The survey measures attitudes by sex and age, and the barriers of middle-aged founders were reported. But the week honours founders without changing the institutions they meet, the limit of policies aimed at women rather than institutions (Ahl & Nelson, 2015), and the new view of small business owners was a statement.

### 2.3.2 JAPAN: THE JFC SURVEYS AND THE CONSULTATION WEEK FOR WOMEN

The JFC Research Institute's survey found women at 24.5 % of founders financed by the JFC, the highest since its survey began in 1991 (Japan Finance Corporation Research Institute, 30 November 2022, p. 1). The JFC held its 11th start-up consultation week for women and young people from 1 November to 26 December (JFC, 15 November 2022, p. 2), and the Start-up Plan cited that 77 % of people interested in founding saw debt or personal guarantees as the risk of failure (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022, p. 15).

This was a mixed policy. The survey measures women's share among founders, and the Plan identifies a barrier that the guarantee reform addresses. But the consultation week works on would-be founders rather than on the lenders and investors they meet (Ahl & Nelson, 2015), and no measure addressed attitudes to disabled or older founders.

### 2.3.3 CHINA: MASS ENTREPRENEURSHIP WEEK AND MODEL INDIVIDUAL BUSINESSES

The NDRC and other bodies, the All-China Women's Federation among them, asked for the national mass entrepreneurship week and contests of 2022 to promote graduates' entrepreneurship (NDRC et al., 8 February 2022, Part V). The General Office of the State Council made 2022 a publicity year for the employment of disabled people (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 25 March 2022, Part III, item 5), the opinions on veterans provided for a roll of honour of firms that hire them (Ministry of Veterans Affairs et al., 6 January 2022, Part III, item 8), and the Regulation asks governments to reward model individual businesses (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 1 October 2022, Art. 29).

This was a mixed policy. Recognition of model individual businesses is in force, and the contests reach graduates. But the publicity year and the roll of honour address employment rather than founding, and none of the measures counted founders by sex or group.

### 2.3.4 UNITED KINGDOM: THE TARGET FOR WOMEN AND THE SMALL BUSINESS SURVEY

Launching the Taskforce on Women-Led High-Growth Enterprises on 26 May, the Government set out its target of raising the number of female entrepreneurs by half by the end of the decade, nearly 600,000, and said that only one in three UK entrepreneurs is a woman (Government Equalities Office, 26 May 2022, release). The BEIS's survey found that in 2021, 20 % of businesses with no employees were majority-led by women and 5 % by people from a minority ethnic group (BEIS, 31 August 2022, p. 2), and the final statistics of the New Enterprise Allowance showed 42 % of its

starters to have been women and about 63,000 to have had a disability (DWP, 15 June 2022, main text).

This was a mixed policy. The statistics count owners and participants by sex, ethnicity and disability, and the target gives a measure to judge against. But the target rested on a taskforce that works by convening investors, and the release widening Start Up Loans gave no figures by sex or ethnicity (BEIS, 25 September 2022).

### 2.3.5 UNITED STATES: SMALL BUSINESS WEEK AND THE CENSUS DATA ON OWNERS

The President's proclamation for National Small Business Week cited almost 5.4 million new business applications in 2021 and more women and members of minorities starting enterprises (President of the United States, 29 April 2022, p. 26668). The Census Bureau's data of 10 November showed that in 2020, 19.9 % of employer firms were minority-owned, 21.4 % women-owned and 5.6 % veteran-owned (U.S. Census Bureau, 10 November 2022, release).

This was a mixed policy. The Census data count employer firms by the owners' sex, race and veteran status, the basis for judging measures aimed at those groups. But the proclamation celebrated founders without new measures.

### 2.3.6 FRANCE: THE REBOUND CONFERENCE AND THE CITY TALENTS CONTEST

The Entrepreneurs' Rebound Conference of 15 February, organised by the Rebound Portal, set out to change attitudes to business failure (MEFR, 16 February 2022, release). The City Talents contest of Bpifrance and the ministry in charge of cities drew 720 applicants from priority neighbourhoods and gave national prizes to seven (Bpifrance, 25 November 2022, release), and the Pépite Prize gave EUR 10,000 each to 33 student winners (MESR, October 2022, p. 4). INSEE found that women created 41 % of new sole proprietorships in 2021, a share little changed since 2015 (INSEE, 2 February 2022, section on women).

This was a mixed policy. INSEE counts creators by sex and age, and the conference addresses the stigma of failure. But the contests celebrate a few winners among hundreds of applicants, and women's flat share of creators met no measure.

### 2.3.7 GERMANY: THE ROLE-MODEL INITIATIVE AND THE KFW START-UP MONITOR

The Start-up Strategy welcomed founding from all walks of life (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 2) and promised to strengthen the role-model initiative for women entrepreneurs (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 10). KfW found women at 42 % of business founders in 2021, against a long-term average of 39 % (KfW Research, 30 May 2022, p. 1), but at 19 % of start-up founders on average in 2017–2021, and named gender stereotypes as the main cause of women's lower preference for founding (KfW Research, 14 November 2022, summary and p. 3). Women were 20.6 % of team members in EXIST start-up stipends in 2021, against 13 % in 2018 (BMWK, April 2022, p. 23).

This was a mixed policy. KfW and the BMWK count founders by sex, including in start-ups and in EXIST. But the role-model initiative works on women rather than on the investors they meet (Ahl & Nelson, 2015), and its strengthening was a promise.

## 2.4 SUPPORT: INSTITUTIONAL SUPPORT

Institutional support reached women, young, older and foreign founders and deprived places through centres and programmes, but one route for the unemployed closed and few programmes reached persons with disabilities.

### 2.4.1 KOREA: THE HOPE RETURN PACKAGE AND MIDDLE-AGED START-UP CENTRES

The Hope Return Package for owners closing and re-starting rises from KRW 115.9 billion to KRW 146.4 billion in the 2023 budget passed on 23 December (MSS, 26 December 2022, pp. 1, 4), and the MSS announced a fast track to give owners who adjust their debts priority in its programmes (MSS, 28 December 2022, release). There were 35 middle-aged technology start-up centres giving space and mentoring to firms within three years of founding (MSS, 7 June 2022, p. 1); 30 of 370 applicants' projects were chosen for the women venture start-up care programme (MSS, 9 November 2022, p. 2); the Global Start-up Immigration Centre of the MOJ reported about 140 foreign start-ups set up since 2015 (MOJ, 4 April 2022, release); and in February the MSS piloted a private-led Youth Start-up Academy for 40 founders aged 39 or under (MSS, 10 February 2022, pp. 1–2).

This was a mixed policy. The centres and programmes reach older, women, foreign and young founders, with places and recipients stated, and the Hope Return Package was funded for 2023. But the fast track was an announcement, and disabled owners were served only through the decree and loans described above.

### 2.4.2 JAPAN: COMMUNITY REVITALISATION COOPERATORS AND WELFARE LOANS

Community revitalisation cooperators, urban residents placed in lagging regions, can receive up to JPY 1 million each if they start or take over a business at the end of their term; of 3,310 who stayed in the same municipality, 1,274 had started one (Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications, January 2022, pp. 9–10). For disabled founders the white paper reported welfare-fund loans for a livelihood business and general start-up support in 1,456 certified municipalities that disabled people can also use (Cabinet Office of Japan, June 2022, disability white paper, section 2 (5)). The draft supplementary budget added JPY 340 million for Ainu community halls (Cabinet Office of Japan, November 2022, p. 11).

This was a mixed policy. The cooperator programme pays people who start businesses in lagging regions and reports how many did. But disabled founders were offered a welfare loan and general support, although they less often reach a viable firm (Renko et al., 2016), and the Ainu grant was a draft unrelated to founding.

### 2.4.3 CHINA: DEMONSTRATION BASES AND RETURN-HOME START-UP PARKS

The NDRC and other bodies focused the entrepreneurship-led job creation demonstration bases on graduates, aiming at 2 million quality jobs for a class of 10.76 million (NDRC et al., 8 February 2022, Parts I and II), and graduates from poor households, disabled graduates and the long-term unemployed were to get individual plans (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 May 2022, item 5). The opinions on migrant workers asked for return-home start-up parks, incubation bases and expert advice (MOHRSS et al., 9 November 2022, item 8), and the plan for disabled people asked platform firms to reduce fees for disabled people who start businesses on them (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 25 March 2022, action 3).

This was a mixed policy. Parks, incubation and fee reductions reach returning migrant workers and disabled people where they lack premises and networks. But most measures were requests without budgets or numbers, the bases were judged by jobs rather than firms, and no support was aimed at women founders.

### 2.4.4 UNITED KINGDOM: THE NEW ENTERPRISE ALLOWANCE AND ACCESS TO WORK

The New Enterprise Allowance, which had paid benefit claimants starting a business GBP 1,274 over 26 weeks with mentoring and through which 161,000 businesses had been set up since 2011, closed to new participants on 1 January (DWP, 15 June 2022, main text, sections 1–2). The Taskforce on Women-Led High-Growth Enterprises was to influence investors, with a focus on growth capital (Government Equalities Office, 26 May 2022, release). Inclusive Britain promised support for a bank's programme with universities for entrepreneurs from under-represented backgrounds and an Enterprise Strategy later in the year (Race Disparity Unit & DLUHC, 17 March 2022, pp. 81–82). Access to Work had introduced a flexible application for disabled freelancers and was piloting an adjustments passport (DWP, 24 May 2022, answer).

This was a mixed policy. Access to Work's flexible application reaches disabled freelancers, and the taskforce addresses investors. But the closure of the allowance removed support that had helped claimants set up 161,000 businesses, the programme for under-represented entrepreneurs depended on a bank, and no Enterprise Strategy was published in 2022.

### 2.4.5 UNITED STATES: WOMEN'S BUSINESS CENTERS AND COMMUNITY NAVIGATORS

By January the SBA counted 140 Women's Business Centers and 22 Veterans Business Outreach Centers and had launched the USD 100 million Community Navigator Pilot with 51 navigators (SBA, 21 January 2022, release). On 23 March the Department of the Interior invited applications for grants of USD 100,000 to USD 300,000 a year for business incubators serving Tribal reservation communities (U.S. Department of the Interior, 23 March 2022, p. 16481), and the Treasury planned USD 300 million of technical assistance, partly through the Minority Business Development Agency (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 19 May 2022, release).

This was a mixed policy. The centres, navigators and incubators reach women, veterans, underserved and Native founders through local organisations. But the technical assistance was a

plan, and none of the programmes named disabled founders other than service-disabled veterans, or older founders.

### 2.4.6 FRANCE: THE FRENCH TECH SPRINGBOARD AND ENTREPRENEURSHIP FOR ALL

The French Tech Springboard, for founders who receive social minima, hold scholarships, are refugees or live in priority neighbourhoods, had a budget of EUR 25 million and gives incubated start-ups EUR 30,000; its second edition took 328 people into preparation and 266 winners into incubation, 34 % of them led or co-led by women (MEFR, 21 February 2022, pp. 1–2). A third preparation cohort of 434, open also to residents of rural revitalisation zones, was to begin in mid-October, the ministry said its budget was made permanent, and a survey of two thirds of the first incubation winners found 93 % of their start-ups still active (MEFIDS, 15 September 2022, release). Bpifrance's Entrepreneurship for All programme added buses and kiosks to 105 advice points in priority neighbourhoods in 2021 (Bpifrance, 3 February 2022, release), and on 8 September it named 42 winners of a EUR 10 million call for entrepreneurship in town centres and small towns (Bpifrance, 8 September 2022, release).

This was a good policy. The Springboard defines its targets by need and place rather than by origin, a construction of the target group that, it has been argued, shapes who receives benefits (Schneider & Ingram, 1993), and reports whom it reached and whether their firms survived, and the other programmes put support where founders lack networks. Its limits are that the survival figure covered one cohort and that disabled founders were not addressed.

### 2.4.7 GERMANY: THE FORUM FOR MIGRANT FOUNDERS AND EXIST-POTENTIALE

The Start-up Strategy announced a forum to network migrant founders, for whom missing networks were the central challenge, and said its measures also served rural and structurally weak regions (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, pp. 9–10). The BMWK set up a working group with associations on maternity protection for the self-employed (German Bundestag, 26 September 2022, report). EXIST-Potentiale funded 101 projects at 142 universities, including small universities without earlier EXIST funding, with about EUR 150 million (BMWK, April 2022, p. 24), and the support for weak regions in the Annual Economic Report did not mention founders (Federal Government of Germany, 26 January 2022, p. 48).

This was a mixed policy. EXIST-Potentiale spreads founding support to smaller universities, and the working group brings self-employed mothers into the search for a solution. But the forum was an announcement, and no support was aimed at women, disabled or older founders.

## 2.5 HUMAN CAPITAL: EDUCATION AND TRAINING, AND LABOUR

Human capital measures mostly prepared young, older and disabled people for employment, while routes for foreign founders widened mainly on paper.

### 2.5.1 KOREA: RE-START EDUCATION AND THE TECHNOLOGY START-UP VISA

The government promised field training for about 20,000 prospective owners a year (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 3), and recipients of the re-challenge grant had to complete five hours of re-start education (MSS, 13 July 2022, p. 2). A start-up boot camp lets middle-aged employees prepare a start-up before retirement (MSS, 7 June 2022, p. 1), and for 2023 the MSS funds the Youth Start-up Academy with KRW 84.51 billion and new programmes for would-be founders aged 29 or under (MSS, 29 December 2022, start-up notice, p. 6). Foreigners can found technology firms under the technology start-up visa after training in a programme of the MOJ, and the Minister of Justice promised simpler procedures (MOJ, 4 April 2022, release and annex 2); the K-Startup strategy of 8 September planned to make the visa renewable in practice in two-year steps (MSS, 8 September 2022, p. 3).

This was a mixed policy. Re-start education and the boot camp prepare owners who failed and older employees for founding, and the visa and its training give foreigners a route to found technology firms. But field training at scale and easier renewal of the visa were plans.

### 2.5.2 JAPAN: THE START-UP VISA PLAN AND THE SPECIAL-ZONE GUIDELINE

The Start-up Plan promised to let state-certified private bodies, and not only certified local governments, confirm founders under the start-up visa, which allows a stay of up to one year, and to lengthen the stay (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022, p. 9). A guideline of the Immigration Services Agency revised in December lets foreign founders in national strategic special zones count a certified co-working office as their premises when renewing their status, for up to one year (Immigration Services Agency of Japan, December 2022, pp. 2–3). The Plan would enlarge the Dejima programme, which sends young would-be founders abroad, from 20 to about 1,000 people over five years, recruiting students and women (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022, p. 5), and the Basic Policy asked schools to strengthen entrepreneurship education (Cabinet of Japan, 7 June 2022, basic policy, p. 36).

This was a mixed policy. The revised guideline lowers a cost of premises for foreign founders, and a wider visa route suits the evidence that immigrants who came to study or work start companies more often than natives with similar education (Hunt, 2011). But the private-body route, the longer stay and the Dejima expansion were plans, and the call for entrepreneurship education came without a programme.

### 2.5.3 CHINA: GRADUATE RECRUITMENT RULES AND TRAINING FOR DISABLED PEOPLE

The General Office of the State Council required sex, age and education discrimination in graduates' employment to be prevented, barred pregnancy tests at hiring and set a plan for 1 million internship posts (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 May 2022, items 9, 14, 17), and firms hiring graduates of the year could receive a one-off subsidy of up to CNY 1,500 each (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 24 May 2022, measure 7). The opinions on migrant workers asked for training and forbade older migrant workers to be dismissed across the board for age (MOHRSS et al., 9 November 2022, items 10, 12), and the plan for

disabled people provided entrepreneurship and skills training with subsidies (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 25 March 2022, action 10).

This was a mixed policy. Entrepreneurship training for disabled people and the rule on older migrant workers reach groups with weak links to employers. But most measures prepared people for employment rather than for founding.

### 2.5.4 UNITED KINGDOM: IN-WORK PROGRESSION AND THE INNOVATOR ROUTE

From April the DWP was to extend in-work progression support to every Jobcentre, with GBP 99 million over three years, for low-paid Universal Credit claimants (DLUHC, 2 February 2022, p. 199), and the Autumn Statement brought forward a nationwide offer from September 2023 and a review of workforce participation, with inactivity noted as acute among people over 50 (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, paras. 3.6–3.7); the Growth Plan had promised more support for people over 50 (HM Treasury, 23 September 2022, para. 3.24). Changes to the immigration rules laid on 15 March, implemented on dates from 6 April, let people on the Innovator route who fail the settlement requirements be granted permission to stay instead of being refused (Home Office, 15 March 2022, paras. 6.4, 7.45).

This was a mixed policy. The change to the Innovator route keeps founders who miss settlement in the country. But the measures for low-paid and older people prepared them for employment only, although activity in self-employment rises with age among those who prefer it (Kautonen et al., 2014), and none aimed at the skills of founders.

### 2.5.5 UNITED STATES: RESOURCE PARTNERS AND RURAL MICROENTERPRISE GRANTS

The SBA reported that its resource partners trained or advised more than 1 million entrepreneurs in fiscal year 2021, and its Women's Business Centers nearly 88,000 (SBA, 28 March 2022, performance report, pp. 79, 83). Its PRIME competition of 2022 gave priority to training for disadvantaged businesses serving rural entrepreneurs and owners who speak foreign languages (SBA, 22 September 2022, release), and the Department of Agriculture invited applications for loans and grants to organisations that lend to and train rural microentrepreneurs, with funding subject to the appropriations for fiscal year 2023 (U.S. Department of Agriculture, 31 August 2022, pp. 53448–53450).

This was a mixed policy. Training through women's centres and micro-lenders reaches women, rural and low-income owners. But the rural programme's funding was unconfirmed, and no measure addressed the skills of young, older, disabled or immigrant founders.

### 2.5.6 FRANCE: THE STUDENT-ENTREPRENEUR STATUS AND SELF-EMPLOYED TRAINING

Holders of the national student-entrepreneur status rose to 5,360 in 2021–2022, 16.5 % more than two years earlier, and women's share rose from 33 % to 38 % (MESR, October 2022, pp. 4, 7). The reform of training for the self-employed applied from 1 September, with a decree making their training claims depend on payment of the training contribution (Parliament of France, 14 February

2022, Arts. 12, 19; Prime Minister of France, 29 June 2022, Art. 1). The youth engagement contract had nearly 200,000 contracts by the end of September, and the 2023 finance bill provided for about 25,000 new hiring-aid contracts for residents of priority neighbourhoods, against 36,000 in 2022 (Finance Committee of the Senate of France, 17 November 2022, labour report); a decree of 28 December moved a date in that aid's rules from 31 December 2022 to 31 December 2023, so that it will continue (Prime Minister of France, 28 December 2022, Art. 1).

This was a mixed policy. The student status widens a route for young founders and is reported by sex, and the training reform for the self-employed is in force. But the largest measures for young people and residents of priority neighbourhoods prepared them for employment, and none was aimed at older, disabled or foreign founders.

### 2.5.7 GERMANY: THE START-UP GRANT AND JUNIOR SCHOOL COMPANIES

The Start-up Strategy described the start-up grant with which the Federal Employment Agency can support unemployed people who found a business, without announcing a change (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 9). It wanted start-ups to sponsor junior school companies (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 9) and aimed at a fast, digital visa process for skilled workers, a measure for employees rather than founders (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 7). KfW found founders under 30 at a record 37 % in 2021, while founding by people aged 50 to 64 fell from 107,000 to 95,000 (KfW Research, 30 May 2022, p. 3).

This was a mixed policy. The start-up grant keeps an instrument whose effects for the unemployed have been found lasting, largest for the disadvantaged (Caliendo & Künn, 2011). But no change or results were reported for it, the school companies were an intention, although a student mini-company programme was found to have no significant effect on skills and a negative effect on the intention to found (Oosterbeek, van Praag, & IJsselstein, 2010), and the fall in founding by older people met no measure.

## 2.6 MARKET: MARKET AND INDUSTRY SUPPORT, IPO AND EXIT

Market measures were mostly procurement preferences and place-based tax relief, which served firms owned by women, disabled people or veterans, or firms in poor places, rather than founders from the groups.

### 2.6.1 KOREA: PURCHASE RATIOS FOR WOMEN- AND DISABLED-OWNED FIRMS

On 24 November the MSS restated the statutory purchase ratios of public bodies: at least 5 % of goods and services and 3 % of construction from women-owned firms, and at least 1 % of all purchases from disabled-owned firms (MSS, 24 November 2022, p. 1); the September decree extended priority purchasing to social cooperatives run by disabled people (MSS, 13 September 2022, p. 2). The government planned to train 100,000 small business owners a year in e-commerce (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 3).

This was a mixed policy. The ratios reserve public demand for women- and disabled-owned firms. But the release reported awards rather than purchases against the ratios, so whether they were met is not shown, and the training in online sales was a plan.

### 2.6.2 JAPAN: BONUS POINTS IN PUBLIC PROCUREMENT

National bodies award extra points in procurement to firms certified under the Act on Promotion of Women's Participation, and the priority policy for women promised to publish how they are applied (Headquarters for Creating a Society in Which All Women Shine & Headquarters for the Promotion of Gender Equality, 3 June 2022, p. 19). The Basic Policy promised to promote standardised electronic invoices among small and medium-sized firms before the invoice system starts in October 2023 (Cabinet of Japan, 7 June 2022, basic policy, p. 19).

This was a mixed policy. Bonus points reward employers that advance women rather than asking women to change. But they serve certified employers rather than women-owned firms, and the invoice support was for small firms in general.

### 2.6.3 CHINA: THE 832 PLATFORM AND SUPPLIER PRIORITY FOR VETERANS

The notice of 17 November admits to the 832 Platform for government procurement enterprises, farmers' cooperatives and family farms registered in the 832 counties lifted out of poverty (General Office of the Ministry of Finance, General Office of the Ministry of Agriculture and Rural Affairs, Comprehensive Department of the National Rural Revitalisation Administration, & General Office of the All-China Federation of Supply and Marketing Cooperatives, 17 November 2022, Part I, item 1). Veteran-founded firms and firms where veterans are 20 % of the staff of small firms may be given priority, under equal conditions, in the military's supplier lists (Ministry of Veterans Affairs et al., 6 January 2022, Part II, items 2–3), and the Regulation bars discrimination against individual businesses in government procurement (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 1 October 2022, Art. 16).

This was a mixed policy. The platform opens public demand to producers in poor counties, and the ban on discrimination is in force for individual businesses. But the platform serves firms in places rather than founders from disadvantaged groups, and the priority for veterans was a request without terms.

### 2.6.4 UNITED KINGDOM: THE PROCUREMENT BILL

The Procurement Bill, which the Cabinet Office set out on 12 May, would require contracting authorities to consider SMEs, extend 30-day payment terms and let buyers reserve competitions below certain thresholds for SMEs and social enterprises (Cabinet Office of the United Kingdom, 12 May 2022, news story). The BEIS's survey found late payment an obstacle for 24 % of businesses without employees (BEIS, 31 August 2022, p. 2).

This was a poor policy. The bill was not law, its measures are for small firms in general rather than for women-, minority- or disabled-owned firms, and no supplier-diversity rule was set out.

### 2.6.5 UNITED STATES: CONTRACTING GOALS FOR DISADVANTAGED FIRMS

In fiscal year 2020 the federal government exceeded its contracting goals for service-disabled veteran-owned firms, at 4.3 % against 3 %, and for small disadvantaged businesses, at 10.5 % against 5 %, but missed the goal for women-owned firms, at 4.8 % (4.9 % in its table) against 5 %, and the goal for small disadvantaged businesses rose to 11 % for fiscal year 2022 (SBA, 28 March 2022, performance report, pp. 63–64, 76). The SBA reported reforms that require agencies to track new contractors and plan to diversify their suppliers (SBA, 21 January 2022, release), and the President restated a pledge to raise contracting with underserved businesses by up to 50 % by the middle of the decade (President of the United States, 29 April 2022, p. 26667).

This was a mixed policy. The goals and their reporting measure reach by group, and the goals for service-disabled veterans and disadvantaged firms were exceeded. But the goal for women-owned firms was missed, the contracting increase was a pledge, and preferences have been found to raise procurement costs, mainly by changing which firms win subcontracts (Marion, 2009).

### 2.6.6 FRANCE: URBAN FREE ZONES AND RURAL REVITALISATION ZONES

Firms set up in the 100 urban free zones in priority neighbourhoods are exempt from tax on profits for eight years under conditions, at an estimated EUR 132 million in 2022 (Finance Committee of the Senate of France, 17 November 2022, city policy report, programme 147), and the finance act for 2023 keeps the exemption of premises in these zones from an office tax in three south-eastern departments (Parliament of France, 30 December 2022, Art. 75). The exemptions of the rural revitalisation zones, covering 17,732 communes at EUR 299 million in 2022, had been prolonged to 31 December 2023 pending a reform of the zoning (Finance Committee of the Senate of France, 17 November 2022, regional policy synthesis, pp. 3–4).

This was a mixed policy. The zone exemptions are in force and lower taxes on firms created in deprived neighbourhoods and rural communes. But they serve places rather than founders from disadvantaged groups, the rural zones awaited reform, and no inclusive procurement measure was set out.

### 2.6.7 GERMANY: PUBLIC CONTRACTS FOR START-UPS AND YOUNG FIRMS

The Annual Economic Report planned to make it easier for start-ups and young firms to win public contracts (Federal Government of Germany, 26 January 2022, p. 68), and the Start-up Strategy promised simpler, digital award procedures and a central notice service (Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 13). KfW reported that 83 % of German venture capital deals went to all-male founding teams and 5 % to all-female teams (KfW Research, 14 November 2022, press release).

This was a poor policy. The procurement measures were intentions for start-ups in general, no measure opened public markets to women, migrant or disabled founders, and the male share of venture deals met only an announced fund instrument.

# 3 ANALYSIS OF THE POLICIES

## 3.1 CONTEXTUAL ANALYSIS: ORIGINS, BACKGROUND AND RATIONALE OF THE POLICIES

A change of government in Korea and a change of Prime Minister in the United Kingdom shaped the year. Korea's new government made the recovery and leap of small business owners and the self-employed its first national task (MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 1). In the United Kingdom the Growth Plan of 23 September announced lower contributions and the repeal of the off-payroll reforms (HM Treasury, 23 September 2022, paras. 3.20, 3.44); after Liz Truss left office and Rishi Sunak was appointed Prime Minister on 25 October (Prime Minister's Office of the United Kingdom, 25 October 2022, speech and appointments), the Autumn Statement of 17 November reversed the repeal (HM Treasury, 17 November 2022, table 5.2). Table 2 sets out how the problem was represented in each country, a representation that, it has been argued, shapes the solutions chosen and leaves some questions unasked (Bacchi, 2009; Rochefort & Cobb, 1993).

***Table 2: How the governments represented the problem***

| Country | Problem represented | Presupposition | Left unsaid |
|---|---|---|---|
| Korea | Owners seen as subsistence-type and in debt after the pandemic | Debt relief and re-start support will turn them into entrepreneurs | Disabled founders beyond purchasing; women's share of founding |
| Japan | Personal guarantees deter founding; freelancers unprotected | Loans without guarantees and a freelance law will lower the risk | Disabled and older founders; when the law will come |
| China | Employment pressure on graduates, migrant workers and other key groups | Start-ups and individual businesses are channels of employment | Women and foreign founders; take-up of the loans |
| United Kingdom | Too few women founders and a finance gap for them | Voluntary action by investors and taskforces will close it | Claimants who start businesses after the allowance closed |
| United States | Underserved communities denied capital and contracts | Mission lenders and state credit programmes can reach them | Whom the credit reaches; disabled and older founders |
| France | Sole proprietors exposed to the failure of their business | Separating estates and an allowance will protect them | Women and foreign founders; disabled founders |
| Germany | Women and migrants under-represented among start-up founders | Announced funds, stipends and networks will raise their share | Older and disabled founders; founders out of unemployment |

Source: IFEED analysis after Rochefort and Cobb (1993) and Bacchi (2009) of the governments' own statements (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022, p. 15; Federal Government of Germany, 28 July 2022, p. 9; Government Equalities Office, 26 May 2022, release; MSS, 25 August 2022, p. 4; Parliament of France, 14 February 2022, Art. 1; State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 March 2022, paragraph on employment; SBA, 21 January 2022, release).

Budgets bore on the measures. Korea's National Assembly passed an MSS budget of KRW 13.5205 trillion for 2023 on 23 December, with KRW 4.2605 trillion for small business owners and the self-employed (MSS, 26 December 2022, pp. 1, 3); China planned tax refunds and cuts of about CNY 2.5 trillion (State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 March 2022, paragraph on tax and fee

relief); France's finance act for 2023 provided EUR 597,541,138 for city policy (Parliament of France, 30 December 2022, Statement B); and Germany's pandemic support, about EUR 60 billion of aid paid and EUR 55 billion of loans by January (Federal Government of Germany, 4 January 2022, p. 1), was extended only to the end of June (Federal Government of Germany, 1 April 2022, article).

Korea and Japan treated the theme mainly as one of debt and the cost of failure, China as one of employment, France as one of the legal exposure of sole proprietors and of places, the United Kingdom and Germany as one of women's participation, and the United States as access for underserved communities, constructions of target groups that, it has been argued, allocate benefits and burdens (Schneider & Ingram, 1993).

## 3.2 THEORETICAL ANALYSIS: THEORETICAL VALIDITY AND RELEVANCE

The evidence on the barriers that particular groups face supports some of the year's measures and not others, as Table 3 shows.

***Table 3: Theoretical validity of the main policies***

| Theory | Claim | Policies consistent with it | Policies in tension with it |
|---|---|---|---|
| Credit (Blanchflower et al., 2003; Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998) | Lack of capital deters founders; credit markets can discriminate | Guaranteed loans (China); mission lenders and state credit (United States); Start Up Loans (United Kingdom) | Debt relief rather than founding credit (Korea); no finance for disabled or older founders (United Kingdom) |
| Start-up subsidies (Caliendo & Künn, 2011) | Subsidies for the unemployed have lasting effects, largest for the disadvantaged | Start-up grant kept (Germany) | Allowance for claimants closed (United Kingdom) |
| Cost of failure (Armour & Cumming, 2008; Lee et al., 2007) | A lower cost of failure encourages entry | Separate estates and allowance (France); New Start Fund (Korea); re-challenge rule (Japan) | Minimum Income Floor exclusion (United Kingdom) |
| Immigrant founders (Hunt, 2011; Kerr & Kerr, 2020) | Immigrants found firms out of proportion to their numbers | Special-zone guideline (Japan); Innovator settlement (United Kingdom) | Employee visa only (Germany) |
| Women founders (Ahl & Nelson, 2015; Ewens & Townsend, 2020) | Policy aimed at women alone leaves institutions, including investors, unchanged | Investing in Women Code (United Kingdom); bonus points for employers (Japan) | Venture week (Korea); consultation week (Japan); role models (Germany) |
| Disability and age (Kautonen et al., 2014; Renko et al., 2016) | Disabled founders less often reach a viable firm; activity rises with age among those who prefer self-employment | Purchase ratio and cooperatives (Korea); middle-aged centres (Korea) | Welfare loan, general support (Japan); employment-only measures (United Kingdom) |

Source: IFEED assessment of the policies reviewed in Section 2, against the sources named in the first column.

China's guaranteed loans and the US mission lenders address the lack of capital that deters founders without wealth (Blanchflower & Oswald, 1998) and, in the US case, the discrimination that credit markets can show (Blanchflower et al., 2003), though no government reported whom the

credit reached. The lasting effects of start-up subsidies for the unemployed (Caliendo & Künn, 2011) support Germany's start-up grant and cut against the closure of the British allowance. A lower cost of failure (Armour & Cumming, 2008; Lee et al., 2007) supports France's separate estates and Korea's debt relief; the evidence on immigrant founders (Hunt, 2011; Kerr & Kerr, 2020) supports the routes that Japan, Korea and the United Kingdom widened or planned; and the evidence on investors (Ewens & Townsend, 2020; Kanze et al., 2018) supports codes and funds that act on investors, not weeks and role models aimed at women alone (Ahl & Nelson, 2015).

## 3.3 PRACTICAL ANALYSIS: PERFORMANCE, CONTRIBUTION AND IMPACT

By the end of 2022 most measures for the smallest self-employed and for credit were in force, while most of those for women founders, freelancers and foreign founders were plans, drafts or proposals (Table 4).

***Table 4: Status of the main measures at the end of 2022***

| Country | In force or launched in 2022 | Adopted, in force from 2023 | Pending or announced |
|---|---|---|---|
| Korea | New Start Fund (from 4 October); re-challenge grant; disabled-owned enterprise decree; middle-aged centres; purchase ratios | Accident insurance for labour providers (from 1 July 2023); premium support for all owners, youth fund and Hope Return Package (2023 budget) | Definition by turnover; women's fund allocation; fast track; visa renewal |
| Japan | JFC loans; Shoko Chukin loans without guarantees (from October); special-zone guideline | Supervisory guidelines on personal guarantees (from April 2023) | New guarantee without personal guarantees (from March 2023); re-challenge rule (start not stated); freelance law; private-body visa route; regional grant (draft) |
| China | Regulation on individual businesses (from 1 November); Announcements No. 10 and 13; guaranteed loans; 832 Platform | — | Loan deferral, supplier priority for veterans (requested); loans for new urban residents, return-home parks (announced) |
| United Kingdom | Class 2 relief; wider Start Up Loans; Access to Work application; Innovator settlement change; closure of the New Enterprise Allowance | — | Threshold freeze from April 2023; Procurement Bill (pending); ethnicity data pilot; rural fund (announced); off-payroll repeal (reversed) |
| United States | Community Advantage changes; state credit plans; PRIME grants; disadvantage thresholds (from 19 December) | Veteran certification by the SBA (from 1 January 2023) | Rules on 8(a) ownership, mission lenders, transport enterprises and contractors (proposed) |

| Country | In force or launched in 2022 | Adopted, in force from 2023 | Pending or announced |
|---|---|---|---|
| France | Act No. 2022-172 and its decrees; self-employed allowance; Springboard programme; zone exemptions | Finance act for 2023; hiring aid continued in 2023 | Rebound portal funding (no sum); women's entrepreneurship line (bill stage) |
| Germany | Restart aid (to June); simplified basic income support (to March); EXIST-Potentiale | — | Future Fund instrument; EXIST Women; migrant forum; social protection of the self-employed; citizen's income (Bundestag adopted) |

Source: IFEED compilation from the sources cited in Section 2.

Where governments reported performance, they reported outputs, such as the loans of Start Up Loans and of the JFC (BEIS, 25 September 2022, release; JFC, 15 November 2022, p. 1), the approvals of state credit plans (U.S. Department of the Treasury, 19 August 2022, release) or the winners of contests (Bpifrance, 25 November 2022, release). France's Springboard programme reported a survival rate from a survey of one cohort (MEFIDS, 15 September 2022, release), while Korea restated its purchase ratios without the purchases made (MSS, 24 November 2022, p. 1). Performance measures, it has been argued, serve among other purposes to evaluate, control, celebrate or promote (Behn, 2003); those of 2022 served mostly to celebrate and to promote. Table 5 summarises Section 2.

***Table 5: Assessment of the policies by domain and country***

| Domain | Korea | Japan | China | United Kingdom | United States | France | Germany |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Regulation and Law | Mixed | Mixed | Good | Mixed | Mixed | Good | Mixed |
| Finance | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Good | Mixed | Mixed |
| Culture | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed |
| Support | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Good | Mixed |
| Human Capital | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed |
| Market | Mixed | Mixed | Mixed | Poor | Mixed | Mixed | Poor |

Source: IFEED assessment of the policies reviewed in Section 2, on the sources cited there. Where a subsection assessed its policies differently, Mixed is shown.

Good assessments rested on instruments in force that reached the groups directly: France's act for sole proprietors and its Springboard programme, China's regulation on individual businesses, and the US mission lenders and state credit programmes. Poor assessments were confined to markets, where the United Kingdom and Germany set out only intentions or a pending bill for small firms in general. Mixed, the most common assessment, usually meant working measures beside plans or requests for women, freelancers, foreign founders or key groups, or measures that reached employers and places rather than founders.

# 4 POLICY LIMITATIONS

## 4.1 POLICY DEBATES, CONTESTED POINTS AND ISSUES

The policies of 2022 raised five points of contention (Table 6). On the first, the question is whether relief that lowers the cost of failure encourages entry by the groups or only cushions owners already in business.

***Table 6: Debates and contested points in the policies of 2022***

| Issue | What the governments set out | Point at issue |
|---|---|---|
| Cost of failure | Debt restructuring (Korea); separate estates and allowance (France); loans without guarantees (Japan) (FSC, 29 August 2022; Ministry of Economy, Trade and Industry et al., 23 December 2022; Parliament of France, 14 February 2022) | Second chances or moral hazard |
| Protection of the self-employed | Accident insurance (Korea); freelance law (Japan); Minimum Income Floor (United Kingdom) (Cabinet of Japan, 7 June 2022; DWP, 27 June 2022; MOEL, 29 May 2022) | Insurance or self-reliance |
| Targeting by group | Purchase ratios (Korea); key groups (China); mission lenders (United States); need and place (France) (General Office of the State Council of the People's Republic of China, 5 May 2022; MSS, 24 November 2022; MEFIDS, 15 September 2022; SBA, 29 April 2022) | Group, need or place |
| Foreign founders | Visa plans (Korea, Japan); Innovator route (United Kingdom) (Council for the Realisation of a New Form of Capitalism, 28 November 2022; Home Office, 15 March 2022; MSS, 8 September 2022) | Migration control or founders |
| What to count | Loans by sex and age (Japan); deals with women founders (United Kingdom); ratios without purchases (Korea) (BEIS, 28 June 2022; JFC, 15 November 2022; MSS, 24 November 2022) | Outputs or reach |

Source: IFEED analysis of the sources cited.

## 4.2 THEORETICAL LIMITATIONS OF THE POLICIES

The first limitation is that the policies counted loans, participants and winners rather than asked what became of them, the pattern of subsidising the number of start-ups rather than their quality that has been criticised (Acs et al., 2016; Shane, 2009).

The second is a focus on groups, not institutions. Korea, Japan and Germany addressed women founders with weeks, consultations and role models, while the evidence locates part of the gap in investors (Ewens & Townsend, 2020; Kanze et al., 2018); a policy aimed only at the group leaves unsaid the institutions that the group meets (Ahl & Nelson, 2015; Bacchi, 2009).

The third is the neglect of age, disability and training. Activity rises with age among those who prefer self-employment (Kautonen et al., 2014) and disabled founders less often reach a viable firm (Renko et al., 2016), yet measures for them were few and general, and entrepreneurship education was requested, not evaluated, although one student mini-company programme brought no gain in skills (Oosterbeek et al., 2010).

# 5 POLICY IMPLICATIONS

First, governments should measure whom their measures reach. They should publish who applies for and receives their loans, grants and contracts by sex, age, disability and origin, as the JFC does for its loans; Korea should publish purchases against its ratios, China take-up of its guaranteed loans, and the United States whom its mission lenders and state credit programmes reach.

Second, the self-employed should share in social insurance. Korea's accident insurance for labour providers and its premium support for all owners show workable designs; Japan should submit its freelance law, Germany should legislate the unemployment, old-age and maternity protection it announced, and the United Kingdom should review how the Minimum Income Floor treats self-employed claimants.

Third, the cost of failure should be lowered for the smallest owners without closing routes into self-employment. France's separate estates and allowance and Korea's New Start Fund point the way, and Japan should bring its guarantee reform into effect as planned; the United Kingdom should replace support for claimants who start businesses, since the evidence on start-up subsidies shows the largest gains for disadvantaged founders.

Fourth, the doors for foreign founders should open as promised. Japan's guideline for special zones and the British change to the Innovator route show that small rule changes can help; Japan should open confirmation to private bodies, Korea should make its visa easier to renew, and Germany should give founders, not only employees, a route.

Finally, measures for women should change the institutions that women founders meet rather than their visibility alone. Asking investors to report deals by the sex of founders, as the Investing in Women Code does, funding diverse investment teams, as Germany announced, and following women's share in official statistics address the evidence; weeks and contests do not. Every measure should come with a plan to evaluate its effect on the groups it names.

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